

Please read the three opening paragraphs from Tung-Hui Hu's *A Prehistory of the Cloud* (MIT P, 2015) and consider the questions listed below.

Like the inaudible hum of the electrical grid at 60 hertz, the cloud is silent, in the background, and almost unnoticeable. As a piece of information flows through the cloud—provisionally defined, a system of networks that pools computing power¹—it is designed to get to its destination with “five-nines” reliability, so that if one hard drive or piece of wire fails en route, another one takes its place, 99.999 percent of the time. Because of its reliability and ubiquity, the cloud is a particularly mute piece of infrastructure. It is just there, atmospheric and part of the environment.

Until something goes wrong, that is. Until a dictator throws the Internet “kill switch,” or, more likely, a farmer’s backhoe accidentally hits fiberoptic cable. Until state-sponsored hackers launch a wave of attacks, or, more likely, an unanticipated leap year throws off the servers, as it did on February 29, 2011. Until a small business in Virginia makes a mistake, and accidentally directs the entire Internet—yes, all of the Internet—to send its data via Virginia, and, almost unbelievably, it does. Until Pakistan Telecom inadvertently claims the data bound for YouTube. A multi-billion-dollar industry that claims 99.999 percent reliability breaks far more often than you’d think, because it sits on top of a few brittle fibers the width of a few hairs. The cloud is both an idea and a physical and material object, and the more one learns about it, the more one realizes just how fragile it is.

The gap between the physical reality of the cloud, and what we can see of it, between the idea of the cloud and the name that we give it—“cloud”—is a rich site for analysis. While consumers typically imagine “the cloud” as a new digital technology that arrived in 2010-2011, with the introduction of products such as iCloud or Amazon Cloud Player, perhaps the most surprising thing about the cloud is how old it is.² Seb Franklin has identified a 1922 design for predicting weather using a grid of “computers” (i.e., human mathematicians) connected by telegraphs.³ AT&T launched the “electronic ‘skyway’”—a series of microwave relay stations—in 1951, in conjunction with the first cross-country television network. And engineers at least as early as 1970 used the symbol of a cloud to represent any unspecifiable or unpredictable network, whether telephone network or Internet. (IX-X)

How does Hu structure the first three paragraphs of this monograph? Is this the most effective way to organize it? If not, which structure could have been used instead?

Which examples does Hu use, for example in the second paragraph, and why? Would you have included the same examples?

Please consider the sentence structure in the second paragraph. What is the pattern adopted by Hu? Do you think that the decision to use it makes sense? What other options could be used here?

Toward the end of the first paragraph, Hu uses adjectives such as *mute* and *atmospheric*. Why do you think Hu chose these instead of, let’s say, *noiseless* or *invisible*, respectively? Which word choices also might be useful here?

Having analyzed the text and considered the decision-making displayed here, do you think that the excerpt from the texts includes anything that might be relevant for one of your writing projects?